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full-time, hourly, or project basis. “Our consistent focus on diversity has resulted in a healthy mix, with 42 per cent women representation at the junior level, 41 per cent at the middle level, and 26 per cent at the senior level,” says Shah.

The ‘Global Gender Diversity 2023’ report by Boardroom Insiders, a consultancy offering executive intelligence, says things have looked up for women at the top since 2014. Although the improvement is relatively minor (around 7-8 per cent), it is part of a positive trend.

Anuradha Acharya, Founder and CEO of MapMyGenome, which offers DNA-based counselling for health issues, says women have a lot to offer in this sector because they bring not only their technical expertise but also their compassion, love, care, and multitasking skills. “These are essential qualities for understanding the customer’s needs and delivering solutions that meet them,” says Acharya, an IIT Kharagpur graduate with a Master’s in physics from the University of Illinois, Chicago.

Similarly, Apollo Hospitals is in the 50 per cent-plus club with a board composition boasting equal gender

representation. “The healthcare industry must prioritise gender parity... Redefining power dynamics, increasing women’s presence in decision-making roles, and implementing supportive policies for working mothers are crucial steps,” says Reddy.

Pfizer is also trying to drive gender balance across all its functions. At its manufacturing plants in Goa and Visakhapatnam, it has brought women into the workforce by supporting them with their education, housing and building a sense of community, Nevatia says.

Helping those with physical disabilities is another area tailor-made for women. The World Health Organization says nearly 1.3 billion people, or 16 per cent of the world’s population, experience significant disabilities.

Shilpi Kapoor, CEO of BarrierBreak & 247 Accessible Documents, a digital accessibility firm, emphasises the significant presence of women in roles such as trainers, counsellors, therapists, and accessibility professionals. Women comprise 48 per cent of the team at BarrierBreak.

CHALLENGES IN PASSING THE TORCH

Apollo’s Reddy can’t agree more that while progress has been made in women’s representation, there is a persistent gap, especially in internal promotion rates. “To enhance women’s leadership, collaborative efforts are essential, focussing on promoting women across various levels and functions,” she says.

Jain says women face some challenges and advantages in general. “One challenge is the gender imbalance, particularly in leadership roles, which can sometimes lead to a lack of representation and potential biases. This challenge is not specific to this industry but is applicable across industries. Also, making valuable connections and finding mentors can be challenging for women leaders,” says Jain. “They may not have the same access to important networks as men do, which can make it harder for them to build meaningful relationships that can help them in their leadership journey.”

Pfizer’s Nevatia says things are changing for the better, but slowly. Women leaders in healthcare and pharma are showing the way. “The more an organisation can mirror the demographics of its target customers, the more likely it is to understand the unmet need truly,” says Nevatia. She says diversity is a long way off in areas such as manufacturing and customer-facing roles, primarily due to the need for early morning or late evening travel on occasion that comes with these roles.

To see women workers streaming into factories is good. Why not imagine streams of women moving up to the boardroom? **BT**

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